

It would be like logging on to www.thinkdigit.com or reading a few articles in *Digit*, and then having to write to digit-magazine.editor@gmail.com or to thinkdigitwebsite@rediffmail.com to send in your feedback or contact our staff!

OK! Agreed, it's ridiculous for free e-mail addresses to appear in a business environment, especially to customers. So what can you do about it? You have two options available: set up an e-mail server at your office, or get your-name@yourdomain.com hosting from one of the many online options.

E-mail Servers

Though this seems like a logical step to take, it is something that requires manpower and investment. It's not really advisable to set up an e-mail server on a regular machine for small companies, especially if e-mail is critical to the functioning of the company.

Also, this solution requires dedicated manpower that checks and maintains the e-mail server on a regular basis. Since most stable and free e-mail solutions are open source and built for Linux, you will need to find staff that is well versed with Linux.

However, the salaries you will have to shell out for one or two such people will easily cross Rs 1 lakh per annum. Smaller firms might not be able to afford this.

Now comes the hardware part: a typical server, is at worst, a dedicated desktop running Linux and a mail server such as Qmail, along with anti-virus software.

Though there are plenty of Windows-based mail servers, hardly any of the good ones are



Comparison Chart

Service Name	Rediff Business E-mail	Indiatimes Meramail Business E-mail	Godaddy.com Premium Plan
Number of E-mail IDs	5	6	100
Space	1 GB	1200 MB Email/1GB Briefcase	2 GB
POP3	Yes	Yes	Yes
Web mail	Yes	Yes	Yes
Domain	Registered in your name	Registered to Indiatimes	Domain charges Rs 400 Extra
Terms & Conditions URL	http://hosting.rediff.com/hosting/scripts/terms.phtml	http://meramail.indiatimes.com/meramail/help/MeraMailTerms.jsp	http://www.godaddy.com/gdshop/agreements.asp?
Price per year	Rs 1,695	Rs 1,499	Rs 1,320 + 400
50 or more IDs	Rs 10,200 for 49 IDs	Rs 10,299 for 50 IDs	Rs 1,320 for 100

Essentially, if you are buying a new domain, all you need to do is buy hosting and the business e-mail is provided at no extra cost

free. Moreover, you will always run the risk of infection by spam and e-mail worms.

Of course, your business also needs to have a fat always-on broadband pipe with minimal downtimes. For instance, if your e-mail server goes offline for a few days due to problems with your ISPs, all your mails will begin to bounce back to their senders—something you definitely want to avoid when it comes to business e-mails!

While setting up an e-mail server may be a good option for businesses with over 300 employees, it's generally considered too much trouble and a significant amount of expenditure for smaller companies.

Here at *Digit*, we run our own e-mail server, primarily because our e-mail traffic is measured in terms of gigabytes per day for over 500 e-mail users, and also because we don't have trouble finding qualified personnel. However, smaller companies might not be able to meet this kind of expenditure.

Home AD